
1. One jacket, several outfits

Instead of buying a jacket for every suit or a blazer for every outfit, make the jacket itself your centerpiece. Then, you can find a jacket you love and create several work outfits around it. You'd be surprised at how many skirts and pants you can find that will go well with whatever jacket you choose, and no one will ever know that they weren't made to go together. And, if the outfits are different enough, people won't even notice that you wore the same jacket three times last week!

This is great in more ways than one:

- It saves you money, because you're not buying as many jackets *and* you're not buying overpriced suit combos.
- You get to choose your style, because you choose the jacket that's your centerpiece.
- You're more comfortable, because the jacket is so often the most uncomfortable part of an outfit.
- If there's a downside to this, I haven't found it yet.

2. Better yet, wear a button-down shirt as a jacket

Yeah, it sounds a little crazy, and it doesn't work with every button-down

shirt in your closet, but you would be surprised at how often this does work (and I love it because of how it messes with people's heads).

Here's the plan: wear a tee or a tank with a dressy neckline, and pull on a matching button-down. Keep the buttons unbuttoned and wear your shirt like a jacket. No one will really think it's a jacket, but it will have the same effect in people's heads.

If you're game to try this, look for button-down shirts that are dark-colored or that have vertical stripes in neutral colors. Make sure the button-down you buy isn't too long or too short—it should fall to the place where you like your jackets to fall. Try it on with a tank or a shirt like the ones you'll most likely wear with it, just to check the effect.

3. Layers, layers, and more layers

Layering several different items, as long as it's done tastefully, can make some items of clothing that alone are too informal to wear to the office into something that's totally office-appropriate. Try a couple of T-shirts of different lengths under another with simple gathering or ruching. Or, wear a couple of different-colored tanks under a white button-down shirt. Those are just a couple of ideas. Seriously, the possibilities are endless.